

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness - Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · YouTube Talks · 22:07

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So we are making our way through the discourse on how to establish right awareness. We did the body, then we did feelings, and then we did mental states. So the last section is called the contemplation of mind objects. In the old translation, sometimes they used to talk about thoughts and things like that. But actually, when you read the discourse, it's quite obvious that the mind objects are specific teachings from the Buddha. So they're the five hindrances, the five aggregates, the six sense bases, the seven factors of enlightenment and the four noble truths.

I am going through this at great speed and the purpose and the reason for that is of course there are many good books on this sort of study if you want to take it more deeply. But also I'm always fearful that the meditation turns into a sort of analysis, which is exactly what you don't want. So if you're in the meditation there and you're speaking to yourself and you're saying, "Now, is this a worldly, neither pleasant nor unpleasant feeling? Or is this an unworldly, neither pleasant nor unpleasant?", then in a sense, you've lost the plot.

The idea of studying like this is for it to be in the background and then when we come to *vipassanā* we forget all that. We just watch, we just feel. After *vipassanā* then of course you can reflect – that's not the problem. But it'll be quite clear that all thinking processes have to be put aside when we're just watching, just feeling, just experiencing.

I'll just read it so you get the phraseology of how the Buddha would have talked about it. So how does a bhikkhu – remember this word bhikkhu means anybody who's practicing – abide contemplating mind objects as mind objects? Here, a bhikkhu abides contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the five hindrances. So when something comes into the mind, heart mind really, and it's one of the hindrances, that is an object to be observed, felt, understood.

And how does a bhikkhu abide contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the five hindrances? Here, there being sensual desire in him, a bhikkhu understands there is sensual desire in him. So it's a direct acknowledgement of desire. So this is the benefit of the noting. So it's just "desire, desire." And then of course when it passes and there being no sensual desire in him, he understands

there's no sensual desire in him.

So this is something that we have to really experience for ourselves. If the mind is full of some sort of desire, or if we go through the other hindrances – all the aversive stuff, all the dullness and lethargy, all the restlessness and the guilt, and all that, and finally all these doubts – when these come to mind to actually recognize what it is. And in recognizing what it is, we're also experiencing how it affects us – the agitation of desire, the burning of anger and that sort of stuff. And then when it passes, then you experience the mind, the heart mind without that. And knowing that, you want to move always towards the heart mind which is not disturbed by any of the hindrances.

And so it ends by saying how there comes to be the arising of an unarisen sensual desire. In other words, what triggers the sensual desires and how there comes to be the abandonment of the sensual desire, which is of course not getting involved. So that's the indulgence bit. Remember there's always the original desire comes up and then there's the desire to indulge it. Are you planning your holiday for instance and off you go dreaming about how wonderful it will be? That's when the fetter's out.

And how there comes to be a future non-arising of abandoned sensual desire, which means that eventually the whole process of wrong desire, wrong aversion is completely gone. And that's a high state of realization, what we call the non-returner. So that means that somebody has arrived at a place where the sensual world no longer appeals. It's like when we're children and we grow out of snakes and ladders – snakes and ladders as a game no longer appeals. So we come to a place in our practice where fine, the sensual world is fine but it doesn't draw you into it anymore.

And so he goes on with the other four hindrances – remember the aversion, dullness and lethargy, restlessness and included in there is things like guilt, remorse, shame, things like that, and skeptical doubt. Remember skeptical doubt isn't the honest doubt of the philosopher in us, the sense of wonder. None of this is meant to be taken as gospel – remember we're supposed to be investigating it so it becomes true for ourselves.

Remembering that there's a type of doubt which stops you from doing something, and that's the skeptical doubt. When you say "I can't do something" and you convince yourself you can't do it, and that stops you from doing it. Something that perhaps we've all experienced is on the high diving board, and you might have got up there and you're just too afraid to go into it, "can't do it, can't do it," until somebody pushes you, then of course you get in.

So skeptical doubt is different from what you might call an honest doubt, which is what we're supposed to have. We're supposed to have an attitude of curiosity, of finding out whether the Buddhist teaching is actually true for us. And that's the process of the enlightenment, you might say. The understanding, the insight – the insight won't come unless we are investigating for ourselves.

And of course, he does this – you're aware of it within you, but you can also be aware of these things in

others – greed in others, anger in others and so forth. And then of course there's always this vanishing factors and arising factors, both the arising factors and vanishing factors. So always this realization or this constant understanding that things are continuously arising and continuously disappearing. That's the *anicca*, that's the impermanence of what it is that we're experiencing.

And then finally, when we get to that point of *vipassanā* where we're just watching, just feeling, just experiencing, simply established in him to the extent necessary for – now the word is *ñāṇa*, and it's translated here as bare knowledge. But *ñāṇa* is a similar word to *paññā*, which means to realize, to actually see something directly. And so enough of that intuitive intelligence and awareness to arise. And that word "mattāya", that word "just enough" – just enough for the insight to arise. So that's the investigation of the five hindrances.

Then there are the five aggregates. So if you forget them, let me remind you – there's the body with all its sensations, and it includes the sense bases. Then there's feelings. This is now, those of you know dependent origination, that's the process – the human being in process of creating the world. Mainly the process of how we create suffering, and as we undo that, the process is how we slowly become fully liberated from wrong views and the purification of the heart. So the dependent origination is the description of the process. Now the five aggregates is more a cross-section – if you were to take a human being at any one time and just look at that human being, then you'd come across these five aggregates.

So an aggregate is telling us that it's made up of all sorts of little bits and pieces, like the body – billions of cells. So there's the body, which from the mind's point of view, from our personal experience point of view, of course are the senses. And we'll come to that in a minute. And then there's the feeling.

And then perception. So this is all the meditation stuff that goes on. The perception, which is like a photograph or a photocopy of something, and how that photocopy is changed as we get to experience similar things over and over again, until we reach the higher concepts, things like freedom and happiness, for heaven's sake.

So when those two are combined, feeling and perception, with the will to create something, that's when you have a habit. Sometimes you'll see it translated literally as volitional formations. In other words, the act of will has to be there for something to be done, and when you make an action and you repeat it, then you get the habit. And as they say, a compendium of habits, a whole collection of habits, is your personality. That's all that's all character and personality is – it's a collection of habits. Once you've got that, your destiny. It'll drive you somewhere.

So what our practice is doing is making us look at these habits and decide, "Well look, this habit is going to take me into the hell realm and these habits are going to take me into the heavenly realm. So where do you want to be tomorrow?"

So again, he says, and how does a bhikkhu abide contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of

the five aggregates? Here, a bhikkhu understands such is material form, such is its origin – in other words, aware of the body when it arises like an itch, so you're aware of it, aware of its disappearance and of its arising and passing. And the same with feeling, such as its origins, such as disappearance. Perception, such its origins, such as disappearance. The habits, such as origin and their disappearance, and finally consciousness.

So I'll put that right at the end as it's mentioned – that consciousness. Remember, that's just a screen upon which everything is arising to be known. It's the first act, you might say, of cognition.

So in this way, he abides contemplating objects, mind objects internally. You can often see it in other people too – their feelings, their emotional states, their habits. And that's how we contemplate these mind objects as the five aggregates.

The next one is the six sense bases, the *āyatana* – dimensions, six dimensions, six spheres of experience, because the sense bases are mono, aren't they? So you can only see through your eyes. You can't see through your ears – even if you try very hard through your ears, you can only hear. So they are different ways of experiencing the world, and of course our inner experience too. And so they are to be seen more as dimensions.

And this word *āyatana* is also used to explain *Nibbāna*, because he'll talk about *Nibbāna* as an *āyatana* where all this is not included, where all this does not manifest. It's a very famous verse in the inspiring discourse, inspiring verses, the inspiring verse of *Udāna*, which perhaps we'll come upon another time.

So he, again, it's the same thing. You're observing the eye, he understands forms – the perception in the eye. He understands the fetter that arises with both. So the fetter of course is desire or aversion.

Just as a side point, you can sometimes just, as it were, if you're standing in a park – I think we're allowed now some parks anyway – or in the garden, and if you pan your garden from one side to the other or you pan what you can see out of your window, what you're looking at or what you're being aware of is how the eye picks things up for you. You don't have to try at all. As soon as the eye hits something, then it'll be recognized by the mind. So you can actually step back, as it were, from that process and recognize that it's just happening as a psychological habit, you might say. So that, of course, gives you the sense of, again, *anattā* – not me, not mine.

So he does that with all the other ones. He understands the ear, he understands sounds. He understands the nose, he understands odours. He understands the tongue, he understands flavours. He understands the body, he understands tangibles – what you can feel. He understands the mind, he understands mind objects – what you think, what you emot. And he understands the fetter that's dependent on them both, and he understands how there comes to be the arising of that fetter. So it's always this desire, this aversion, or a certain deluded understanding about what we're experiencing. And so there becomes also the abandoning of that fetter and how there comes to be no more fetters arising.

So these fetters – that's a special word. We've actually touched upon it earlier. There are ten of them and two of them are to do with sensual pleasure and aversion. So they're fetters. They're holding us to this level of existence or to this level of being that we're in, which is causing us suffering at some level or another.

How are we doing with time? Oh, right. Well, I've got enough time to do the seven enlightenment factors.

So much the same. So this one is slightly different because these are beautiful. So again, the bhikkhu abides contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the seven enlightenment factors. How does he do that? Here, the mindfulness enlightenment factor is in him. When you become aware of being aware, "there is this mindfulness enlightenment factor in me." And there being no mindfulness enlightenment factor in me, he understands that. So when the mind has wandered, you wake up and you think, "Ah, that's being mindless."

And then the paragraph is, and he also understands how there comes to be the arising of unarisen mindfulness factor. In other words, what makes mindfulness come, what establishes mindfulness for us, and how arisen mindfulness enlightenment factor comes to fulfillment by development. So in other words, how we can develop this mindfulness to a point where the fulfillment is eventually – not at this point, but eventually – is the liberation, the awakening.

And so he then talks about the investigation states. That's the factor of investigation. Here it's put in a particular form, but the way that I've come to understand it is just by seeing the opposites. So this applies the same to interest, your curiosity, but that has to be balanced with a certain calmness. And then there's concentration which has to be balanced with effort. If there's not enough effort you fall asleep, if there's too much effort you get restless and so on. And equanimity – coming from a place of a balanced heart mind where you can do the investigation clearly.

The investigation is this direct understanding of what it is we're experiencing, which is always from the point of view of relationship, desire, wrong desire, aversion, impermanence, and not self.

And so with all of them, you get this last standard and it says he also understands how there comes to be the arising of what was not there before – how it comes to be all these different seven factors of enlightenment, and how to maintain it and develop it to its fullness. And at which point, hopefully some liberation arises.

So I think we can leave it there and we'll just finish it off tomorrow evening.

So again, apologies for rushing through this, but as I say, there are many texts and this is a very fulsome discourse on it. There are other scriptures, the main one being the Sarvāstivādin. So this was another school which existed at the same time as Theravada, but seems to have died out. But their scriptures were kept in Chinese and they've now virtually been all translated. And so we now have a translation of their *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, their discourse on how to establish awareness. And it's not as full as this. So this has

been obviously augmented. It's been made fuller. It's grown over time with memory from what the Buddha was teaching, trying to get it all together in one discourse.

So remember, even though we know all this, when we're sitting, we're not trying to be analytic, all right? That's bringing the head in, and you don't want the head. You want just pure awareness, pure intuitive. We're just watching, just feeling, just experiencing.

So I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your devotion to practice, be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

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